

Generational imprinting: how political events shape cohorts

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Abstract

Contemporary narratives of generational politics propose that formative experiences produce shared political opinions across an age cohort. In this article, I advance a theory of cohortization to challenge that view, arguing that large-scale political events produce differentiation within cohorts as much as differentiation between them. I investigate the implications of this framework through the killing of George Floyd and the subsequent Black Lives Matter protests in 2020, analyzing attitudes toward law enforcement among non-Hispanic White Americans from 2016 to 2024. Using survey data from Cooperative Congressional Election Study, American National Election Study, and the Nationscape, I show that younger and older cohorts diverged after the event, but this differentiation was driven exclusively by young Democrats and Independents. The end result was not a unified generation, but one internally divided along party lines. This finding qualifies theories of generational politics, emphasizing that formative experiences may intensify existing political divisions within cohorts.

Keywords generations, cohorts, opinion change.

This is my generation
This is my generation, baby
My, my, my, my generation
— The Who, “My Generation” (1965)

Generations have become central to contemporary politics. Often invoked to describe birth cohorts whose cultural orientations are said to bear the imprint of formative experiences (cf. Kertzer 1983), generation is presumed to define a coherent cultural collective, spanning from the one-dimensional men of the postwar era to the Woodstock youth and the yuppies of the eighties.

This cultural cohesion (“coming of age” through shared experiences) led scholars to postulate historical generations (e.g., Elder 1974; Jennings and Niemi 2014), many of which were defined with reference to a major political cleavage: the Vietnam Generation formed in opposition to the draft, and those politicized after 9/11 in the shadow of mass surveillance. What—if anything—may unite these birth cohorts as political collectives, however, is a question that has rarely received clear theoretical specification.

This question has important consequences for our understanding of political culture. Generational narratives tend to emphasize differences between birth cohorts, focusing on formative experiences that set one group apart from another. However, the emergence of a generation is a political process as much as a temporal one: ideological competition shapes which social experiences come to count as formative for a given cohort, and within those cohorts, such experiences do not simply produce shared meaning, but *competing interpretations of those very events* (Goldberg and Singell 2024), with prior political dispositions affecting these interpretations. Generational formation, so understood, is a process of political differentiation *within* cohorts as much as a differentiation *between* them.

To explain this process of differentiation, I develop a micro-level model of generational imprinting. This model posits that when a salient political shock introduces a new problem into the information environment, competing actors supply different considerations to frame this problem. In response, people accept considerations that align with their prior dispositions (Zaller 1992), whether because congruent considerations allow people to protect their identities (Kahan 2017), or because they fit more readily with opinions individuals already hold (Achen 1992; Bartels and Jackman 2014). The durability of these considerations, however, depends on the composition of existing consideration sets: for those with few considerations (“the young”), newly accepted ideas face little competition and can settle into chronic baselines, while the trajectories of individuals with many considerations (“the old”) will be less substantial and more transitory. If such changes endure over the life-course, these micro mechanisms of change can produce, at the aggregate level, generational imprinting.

A distinctive prediction of this model compared to impressionable years hypothesis (Krosnick and Alwin 1989; Sears and Funk 1999; Vaisey and Lizardo 2016) and previous accounts of generational formation (e.g., Bartels and Jackman 2014) is *within-cohort* differentiation as much as *between-cohort* differentiation. This within-cohort variability, I theorize, results from what Mannheim (1952) calls “world-interpretations,” basic orientations that divide interpretations of events and, consequently, lead people to react to them positively or negatively. The impressionable years thesis may therefore explain who changes, but only interpretive divergence can explain why people change in different directions. Hence, this model allows us to look for young people who volunteer to fight in Vietnam, rather than purely focusing on the counter-mobilization against it; similarly, it theorizes the young conservatives who supported the War on Terror, alongside those who opposed these practices.

To investigate the predictions of this framework, I examine the killing of George Floyd in 2020 and the subsequent Black Lives Matter (BLM) protests. Drawing from three national surveys spanning 2016 to 2024, I analyze how White Americans changed their attitudes toward US law enforcement, and show that younger cohorts became strongly unfavorable toward the police in response to these events, compared to less substantial and more transitory changes among older cohorts. In contrast to theoretical frameworks that exclusively rely on such between-cohort differences, however, I show that age-based differentiation between younger and older individuals was driven mainly by youth identifying as Democrats and Independents. This, I argue, created a within-cohort differentiation along partisan lines, as much as a between-cohort differentiation between the young and the old.

Taken together, these findings demonstrate how partisan competition can turn a shared experience into divergent trajectories within the same cohort. The durability of these trajectories among young Democrats through 2024 suggests that responses formed around a formative event, in the end, can become durable features of a cohort’s political orientation. This initial persistence,

however, should not itself be understood as evidence of generational imprinting: imprinting requires that divergent trajectories persist over the life course, and become characteristic of the cohort as it ages, something that could only be established with long-term observations. The empirical evidence presented here instead identifies an *impulse toward cohortization*¹: divergent political trajectories within a cohort becoming durable features of its political orientation, potentially yielding generational imprinting.

This article has several theoretical contributions. First, I argue that coming of age in the same period does not necessarily lead to convergent political tastes. Instead, cohorts may internally polarize as a result of competitive struggles that provide competing interpretations of the same formative events. Hence, cohort effects are not, according to this account, self-sufficient drivers of aggregate political change. Second, this article speaks to existing accounts of cohort formation, which can explain who changes without explaining the direction of change (e.g., Mannheim 1952; Ryder 1965; Vaisey and Lizardo 2016). I argue that interpretive divisions available at the time of the event can supply these directional mechanisms, an argument that microfounds Mannheim (1952)'s *generation-units*. In the end, this article presents a useful corrective to popular narratives about generations by theorizing the field of politics as an engine that turns shared experiences into divergent political outcomes.

A theory of generational imprinting

The problem of generations has long been a central issue in classical sociological theory (Mannheim 1952; Ryder 1965), with recent accounts in cultural sociology highlighting the role of cohortization as an engine of cultural change (Vaisey and Lizardo 2016). Scholars typically interpret generations as products of cohort effects, which emerge from the interaction of period effects (i.e., cultural and political processes shaping the range of experiences) and age effects (i.e., the differential responses to environmental stimuli across age groups). Hence, cohortization is often theorized as *period effects experienced at an early age*, that is, *differentiation* in these early experiences (Morgan and Lee 2024).

This formulation has important advantages for explaining political change. It fits well with classical socialization paradigms that propose sensitive windows early in life, during which individuals are more likely to change (Krosnick and Alwin 1989) and form identities (Jennings and Markus 1984), more willing to assign greater weight to new information (Achen 1992; Bartels and Jackman 2014), and more open to influence from socializing agents (Jennings and Niemi 1968) and political events (Sears and Valentino 1997). It also provides a mechanistic account of “fresh contacts” (Mannheim 1952), the classic idea that new cohorts carry “the impress of [these contacts] through life” (Ryder 1965, 844)—a cultural development process commonly referred to as “generational imprinting.”

Yet while this imprinting process is often formulated through distinctive “historical markers” (Alwin, Cohen, and Newcomb 1991; Elder 1974; Mishler and Rose 2007), the theoretical mechanisms through which cohorts become politically differentiated are rather ambiguous.² The ambiguity lies primarily in treating formative events as sufficient explanations of generational imprinting without explaining why a person changes in one direction rather than another. For instance, while the Great Depression (Elder 1974) and the Vietnam War (Jennings and Niemi 2014) are often treated as formative events for their respective cohorts, existing theories rarely clarify whether these events lead to more liberal or more conservative political orientations. In treating shared temporality as shared meaning-making, this framework falls short of explaining the direction of generational change—an issue that has frequently haunted the ambiguous use of the term generations (Kertzer 1983).³

The microfoundations of imprinting

The central reason why major cohortization theories fail to predict the direction of opinion change is that these theories do not have a clear account of the information flows surrounding a social

event. This implies that while cohortization dynamics provide a *demand-side* account of who changes, they ultimately provide no *supply-side* mechanism of directional change, which results in an ambiguity in understanding why an actor forms evaluation *A* rather than evaluation *B*. Hence, it is imperative to proceed from the expectation that, when a new shock introduces a new problem, the actors who compete over its meaning—whichever form that competition takes in a given time and place—will provide considerations that interpret this new shock differently (Goldberg and Singell 2024).

Such competing considerations have direct counterparts on the reception side: an interpretation of an event is patterned by individuals' basic predispositions (Zaller 1992), which (1) exist before the event emerges, (2) divide how the event is interpreted, and (3) affect which considerations people encounter and accept. These predispositions, however, are structured by the social organization of conflict itself: in the contemporary United States, partisan identities structure how people process political information (e.g., Bisgaard and Slothuus 2018; Boutyline and Vaisey 2017; Goren, Federico, and Kittilson 2009; Slothuus and Bisgaard 2020), while in other settings religious, ethnic, regional, or class divisions may play the same role. Whatever its content may be⁴, a predisposition supplies a mechanism for directional acceptance, with people gravitating toward congruent opinions:

Premise 1: *When new political shocks arise, people's predispositions pattern which of the competing considerations they come to hold, producing systematic directional differentiation.*

What about the initial reception and durability of these new considerations? This is where theories on cohortization can extend Zaller (1992). Let me define the set of prior considerations a person has as their pre-existing *consideration set*. One implication of the sensitive window hypothesis is that we may understand different age groups as individuals whose pre-existing consideration sets vary in magnitude and complexity (exemplified in Bartels and Jackman 2014). According to this definition, younger individuals tend to have a smaller set, whereas older individuals tend to have a larger set of considerations. This difference implies that, when a new problem arises in the environment, the influence a new consideration carries varies by age group (Anoll and Engelhardt 2023).

One theoretical implication of this framework is the distinction between *chronic* and *temporary* ideas. Among older individuals, the large consideration set implies that the new cue competes with many priors. This means that an older actor's initial reaction to an emerging issue consideration tends to be weaker. The heat of the event might generate a temporary update, though chronic ideas reassert once recency effects are washed away. Among younger individuals, these new considerations have almost no competition, however. New ideas may come to define how to think about that issue over time, changing temporary considerations to chronic baselines. This difference highlights two main trajectories of opinion behavior: differential response and differential retention. Hence:

Premise 2: *The durability of political change depends on the size of pre-existing consideration sets: younger people, having fewer priors, internalize new political considerations more durably, while older people, having more priors, experience weaker and more temporary change.*

These two premises help us understand mechanisms of opinion differentiation: the extent to which a temporary reaction becomes a chronic disposition thus requires that a new consideration be both identity-congruent (by Premise 1) and relatively powerful compared to existing priors (by Premise 2). When a new issue arises in the environment, a person's evaluative updating is therefore tied to the supply of interpretations, as well as the prior stock of considerations. The final product of these two mechanisms is between-cohort and within-cohort differentiation: over the long run, the former leads to the emergence of *generations*, while the latter leads to the emergence of *generation-units*, so long as both differentiations persist over the life-course, and individuals experience no maturation effects or later shocks that differentially affect cohorts or cohort-units over time. Hence:

Premise 3: *Between-cohort and within-cohort differentiation will lead to generational imprinting only if they persist over the life-course without maturation effects or differential shocks.*

The dynamics of imprinting

When should we expect generational imprinting, given these premises? The theory requires several preconditions: an event must be sufficiently salient, its meaning must be sufficiently contested, and the predispositions organizing the reception of one interpretation over another must be sufficiently crystallized. These conditions imply that between-cohort and within-cohort differentiation emerge from related but distinct mechanisms: between-cohort differentiation requires age-based updating and retention, while within-cohort differentiation additionally requires interpretive divergence in the considerations available to individuals. Neither necessarily produces a generational signature: both must persist across the life course for cohort differences to become generational imprinting. A salient event may therefore produce differentiation between cohorts, differentiation within a cohort into generation-units, or neither, depending on the ideological organization of interpretations.⁵

These parameters—salience, contestation, and crystallized predispositions—vary, of course, with the organization of conflict surrounding an event. The theory is therefore general in its mechanism but historical in its outcomes: the same event might leave different imprints on a cohort depending on how the conflict is organized (along religious, ethnic, regional, or class divisions) when it occurs. To apply this theory in a particular historical context, then, we must ask which political division is sufficiently established to organize how people encounter, interpret, and respond to the event.

The contemporary United States provides an especially tractable context for studying these dynamics because ideological conflict is strongly organized along partisan lines (Baldassarri and Gelman 2008; DellaPosta 2020; Levendusky 2009; Zaller 1992). In this context, partisan identity coordinates both the organization of the political field and the dispositions of individuals on the receiving side: political actors can offer competing interpretations of the same event along partisan lines, while individuals' partisan identities structure which of those interpretations they are most likely to accept. An event can consequently produce divergent responses among members of the same generation, with age structuring the durability of the response and partisanship determining its direction.

Empirical implications

Figure 1 presents a schematic representation of how four actors, defined via a 2×2 table of age and partisan groups, may change their attitudes in response to a salient event. The trajectories provide one stylized instantiation of the opinion differentiation implied by Premises 1 and 2, and emphasize how the durability of event-induced change may differ across age and partisan groups. With these theoretical trajectories as the empirical benchmark, I first state the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1. *Following a political event, younger individuals will exhibit greater changes in political attitudes than older individuals, with the direction of change varying according to the congruence between the event-induced considerations and individuals' partisan identities.*

This hypothesis has a rather precise group-level quantity (Lundberg, Johnson, and Stewart 2021): $\mathbb{E}[Y_{post} - Y_{pre} | A, G]$, i.e., the difference in attitudes before and after a political event, stratified by age groups A (that is, Young and Old) and partisan groups G (that is, parties D and R).

The generalization of this expectation to multiple windows brings us to the question of trajectories, as shown in figure 1, and the prediction of differential change across age-by-party cells:

Hypothesis 2. *The attitude change trajectories diverge across age and partisan identity: the old revert further toward their pre-event attitudes than the young, and among the young, durability depends on whether the new considerations are congruent with their partisan identity.*

The group-level quantity, this time, is $\mathbb{E}[Y_t - Y_{pre} | A, G]$, where the subscript t refers to each time window after the event, allowing us to trace the temporal trajectories of attitude change.

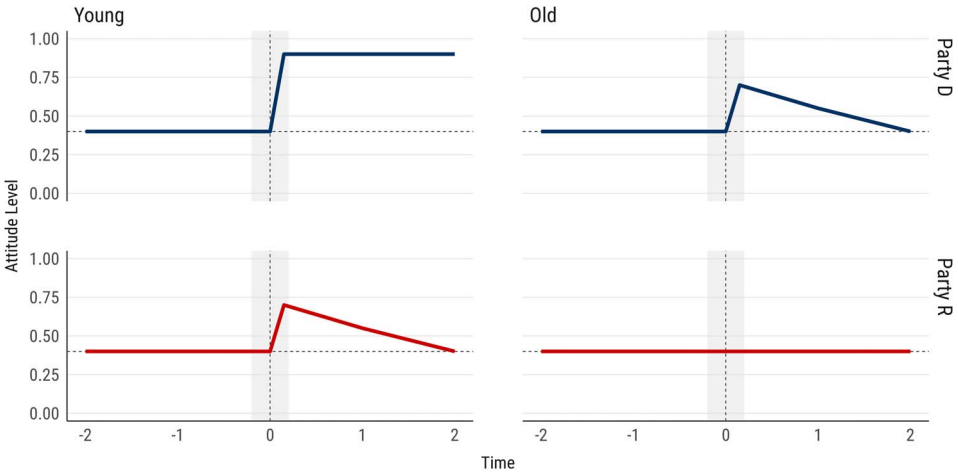


Figure 1 Theoretical trajectories across age and partisan groups.
Notes: The figure presents theoretical trajectories across four groups defined by age (young and old) and party identity (Party D and Party R), with the shaded region at time = 0 representing the event period. These trajectories provide one stylized instantiation of opinion dynamics, and other trajectories consistent with Premises 1 and 2 are possible.

Taken together, Hypotheses 1 and 2 have an important aggregate implication that has been largely overlooked in the generational politics scholarship. The standard expectation is that political events produce between-cohort differentiation, where younger and older cohorts diverge in their average attitudes, leading to the familiar argument of a political generation defined in opposition to older ones. That being said, the micro-dynamics outlined in this section suggest a more complex picture, where within-cohort differentiation, with $|\mathbb{E}[Y_{post} - Y_{pre} | A, G = D] - \mathbb{E}[Y_{post} - Y_{pre} | A, G = R]|$ as its target quantity, becomes an important outcome. This emphasis is important, because analyses relying solely on a cohort's central tendency cannot distinguish a cohort whose members converge on an outlook from one whose members change in opposite or markedly different directions, even though these trajectories have very different implications for aggregate political change.

The empirical setting

I apply this framework to the killing of George Floyd on May 25, 2020, and the ensuing BLM protests. I focus in particular on how non-Hispanic White Americans changed their attitudes toward US law enforcement in response to this event, whether this change differed across age groups and party identities, and whether it persisted or decayed over time. The study window starts as early as the Fall of 2016, long before the event, and runs through the Fall of 2024.

The setting

On May 25, 2020, in Minneapolis, Minnesota, a 46-year-old Black man, George Floyd, was killed during an arrest when a White police officer pressed his knee on Floyd's neck for approximately 9 minutes 29 seconds—a scene recorded by bystanders, and rapidly disseminated online. Within the next few days, protests erupted nationally in the United States, as well as over sixty countries, under the banner of BLM. Survey-based crowd counts place total US participation between 15 million and 26 million, making the BLM mobilization the largest sustained protest movement in the US history (Buchanan, Bui, and Patel 2020). The scale of this mobilization positioned the George

Floyd protests as a salient political event that swiftly re-centered public debate on police violence in the United States, a chronic issue that had been ongoing for years (Edwards, Lee, and Esposito 2019).

The scale and salience of the George Floyd protests make this event an analytically powerful setting for investigating the opinion dynamics of cohortization. Since public attention is a scarce resource (Hilgartner and Bosk 1988) and political elites routinely reinforce identity-congenial signals (Zaller 1992), changes in the political information environment create opportunities for persistent change in attitudes, particularly when political mobilizations successfully shift the public agenda (Wasow 2020). The BLM mobilization in the summer of 2020 represents precisely such a moment, a focusing event that concentrated public and elite attention on racial injustice and police violence.

Of course, the murder of George Floyd was not, in any sense, an isolated event. The years preceding 2020 presented a succession of nationally prominent police violence victims, including, among others, Trayvon Martin, Eric Garner, Tamir Rice, Freddie Gray, Philando Castile, and Breonna Taylor. Such instances already established competing partisan frameworks for interpreting police conduct among the American public. What distinguished the Floyd case, however, was the sheer scale and salience of the ensuing BLM movement, which unfolded precisely at the intersection of an election year, a pandemic that facilitated political engagement virtually, and agenda-seeding mobilization (Wasow 2020). The result was a moment of *concentrated salience*, one that compressed into months the kind of partisan opinionation dynamics that could otherwise unfold across decades.⁶

The target population

I focus analytically on non-Hispanic White Americans, as the dynamics of political opinionation in response to racialized police violence likely differ across racial groups. For racial minorities, particularly Black Americans, encounters with law enforcement are often shaped by direct or vicarious experiences of discrimination, surveillance, and harm, meaning that minority attitudes are more likely to reflect long-standing racial marginalization that informs prior beliefs⁷ and expectations (Jefferson, Neuner, and Pasek 2021). Conversely, among non-Hispanic Whites—who are less likely to experience routine police violence and more likely to benefit from institutional trust—an event like the killing of George Floyd may function as a discrete political shock. That is, the event potentially serves as a socializing incident rather than identity reinforcement.⁸

The target quantity

I focus on attitudes toward law enforcement to evaluate the main theoretical expectations—a core political debate in contemporary US politics. I conceptualize these attitudes as evaluative judgments that may reflect long-standing dispositions among individuals, capturing related constructs about “legal cynicism” (Kirk and Papachristos 2011) and institutional trust (Ben-Menachem and Torrats-Espinosa 2024). These attitudes prove especially significant in moments of salience—when the legitimacy of law enforcement becomes a salient issue of public debate—such as during the aftermath of George Floyd’s killing and the ensuing BLM protests. Attitudes toward law enforcement, in short, are an ideal construct for observing these opinionation dynamics: they are evaluative, politically legible, and sensitive to the kind of salient event this study examines.

Analytic strategy

I use data from three large-scale surveys of American Adults: *Democracy Fund + UCLA Nationscape* (Tausanovitch and Vavreck 2021), henceforth simply *Nationscape*, *Cooperative Congressional Election Study* (Schaffner, Ansolabehere, and Shih 2023), or simply CCES, and the *American National Election Study* (American National Election Studies 2025), or simply ANES. I complement these

data with *Crowd Counting Consortium* (CCC) and *Gallup Poll Social Series* (GPSS) for additional analyses.

Data sources

Nationscape

The Nationscape is a repeated cross-sectional survey, fielded from mid-2019 through the end of 2020, on a large non-probability sample from *Lucid* (now called *Cint*). Surveying roughly 6,250 participants each week over an extended period of time, Nationscape provides detailed data on 312,954 non-Hispanic Whites before and after the killing of George Floyd, and their attitudes toward law enforcement. To increase statistical power, I pooled these weekly installments into 4-week windows and used post-stratification weights to improve the representativeness of the sample. As there are documented concerns about the quality of Lucid-sourced data in this time window, I treat the Nationscape analysis as a *consistency check* rather than a formal test of the basic hypotheses.

CCES

To understand how younger and older cohorts respond to the events of summer 2020, I use data from the 2016, 2020, and 2022 waves of the CCES, a large-scale survey program administered by YouGov. The CCES uses a matched random sampling strategy to recruit American participants, complementing it with poststratification weights derived from the United States. Census to adjust for sample imbalances. In the end, I analyze 127,763 non-Hispanic White participants across three waves.

ANES

Analyses with repeated cross-section surveys help us understand trajectories across *groups*, but they do not provide direct evidence within *individuals*. Hence, I complement the Nationscape and CCES with panel data from the 2016, 2020, and 2024 waves of the ANES. The panel design is particularly well-suited to assess within-person change, though the sample is smaller ($N = 1,507$), limiting precision in subgroup analyses. Nonetheless, the ANES provides a probability-based gold standard, and because the same individuals are observed over time, the ANES panel also helps rule out compositional changes as an unobserved driver of the observed generational differences.

Since these surveys offer distinct benefits, I use them all to triangulate the central expectations. The ANES provides the highest-quality sample, with the voting-eligible adults as its target population, and a panel design that tracks the same individuals across the study window. That said, its modest sample size limits the precision in subgroup analyses. The CCES, designed to be representative of all national adults in the United States, offers large N surveys across multiple waves, enabling more granular subgroup analyses than the ANES. That said, it is cross-sectional and vulnerable to compositional changes, as well as having a slightly less rigorous probability design compared to the ANES.

The Nationscape is arguably the lowest-quality survey data among the three sources: it draws on a non-probability online survey panel, where inattentive or automated responding is a documented concern (Westwood 2025; but also see Coppock and McClellan 2019). Moreover, its window closes 6 months after the event, which is too short to establish long-run patterns. That said, its granular resolution is something neither the ANES nor CCES can supply: this granularity is what allows me to characterize the immediate response to the event, to explore how that response evolves over the following months, and to compare age-by-party-group trajectories in the windows right before the event occurred. I therefore retain the Nationscape for the dynamic analyses, and rely on the ANES and the CCES for the larger empirical claims that require a better sample quality to establish.

In addition to these survey sources, I use crowd-sourced data from the *Crowd Counting Consortium* (CCC)—a project of Harvard Kennedy School and the University of Connecticut—that compiles

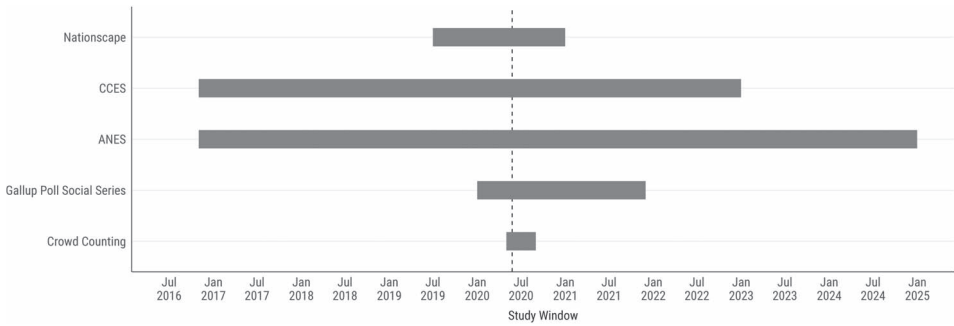


Figure 2 The study timeline and the data sources used.

publicly available data on demonstrations in the United States. Following prior work (Gethin and Pons 2024) as well as suggestions from the CCC team, I filtered for demonstrations protesting issues related to *race* and *racism* within the first three months after the killing of George Floyd, matching this information to the Nationscape at the congressional district level and CCES at the county level. I leverage the intensity of protests in one's personal local environment as a proxy for their plausibly direct exposure to BLM mobilization, measured as the count of protests recorded in the CCC data. To test changes in differential attention to political issues in the United States, I use data from the *Gallup Poll Social Series*, which features the *most important problems* (MIP) questions in 2020 and 2021 monthly surveys. I similarly use time-series estimates from the ANES in 2016 and 2020 to complement these scores. In both cases, I rely on the coding of open-ended data provided by each organization.

Figure 2 provides a general overview of the study timeline, as well as the data sources used in the analyses. I present additional details about data processing in Supplemental Materials A. Table S1 through Table S5 provide descriptive statistics for all three data sources used in the analyses.

Measurement

I operationalize *attitudes toward law enforcement* using three separate survey questions, each featured in one data source: (1) the favorability of the police in Nationscape, (2) one's feelings of safety with the police in CCES, and (3) the police thermometer rating in ANES.⁹ Across all surveys, I recoded the items so that higher values indicate more unfavorable attitudes toward law enforcement.

The measurement strategy in Nationscape and ANES is relatively straightforward—each capturing evaluative judgments on the US police as an institution. Of course, the question from CCES taps a more personalized dimension of one's interactions with police officers, and it might not necessarily reflect a politicized response.¹⁰ Despite these differences in emphasis and wording, however, it still captures an underlying evaluative disposition toward US law enforcement, allowing me to present partial, albeit converging, evidence on the central expectations across a longer time window.

I split people into two categories by their age in 2020, the year of the event: those aged 29 or younger, and those aged 30 or older. Since this strategy uses age in 2020, group membership is fixed across waves, so a respondent who was 28 in 2020 remains in the younger group when observed again in 2022 or 2024. To measure partisanship, I use three groups (Democrat, Independent, and Republican), coded in each wave. In the Nationscape and the CCES, these come from the three-point party identification item, with respondents who identify with neither party coded as "Independent." In the ANES, the categories are coded from the seven-point partisanship item, with leaners assigned to their respective parties, though this coding decision does not affect the substantive findings.

Statistical strategy

The event of interest, for all analyses, is the killing of George Floyd and the ensuing BLM mobilization. Since exposure to this event was effectively population-wide, I focus on differential responses across groups, rather than relying on the average effect of the event itself. The theory predicts that these responses should vary along two dimensions: age, which I tie to the size of one's pre-existing consideration sets, and partisan identity, which shapes which political frames are internalized. Let Y_{it} denote the attitude of individual i at time t , $A \in \{0, 1\}$ the age group, with 0 = the old and 1 = the young, G one's partisan identity, and $P \in \{0, 1\}$ whether the time is pre-event or post-event.

The first estimand is the within-group change in attitudes:

$$\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A, G, P = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A, G, P = 0] \quad (1)$$

Equation (1) shows the baseline quantity predicted in [Hypothesis 1](#), the dynamic analog of which allows us to observe the trajectories predicted by [Hypothesis 2](#). To test differential updating across age groups, however, we need to extend this strategy and examine the cross-group differences:

$$(\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A = 1, G, P = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A = 1, G, P = 0]) - (\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A = 0, G, P = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A = 0, G, P = 0]) \quad (2)$$

Equation (2) is a difference-in-differences (DID) quantity capturing polarization between younger and older individuals within a partisan group. To examine the trajectories predicted in [Hypothesis 2](#), I estimate the dynamic analog of Equation (1) for each event window t , rather than pooling over the full post-window. In both cases, Equation (2) estimates the differential responses between the young and the old, thereby quantifying between-cohort differentiation for each partisan group.

The third estimand captures within-cohort differentiation, the divergence between partisan groups inside a single age group:

$$(\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A, G = D, P = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A, G = D, P = 0]) - (\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A, G = R, P = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Y_{it}|A, G = R, P = 0]) \quad (3)$$

Equation (3) has the exact same DID structure as Equation (2), with the roles of age and partisan identity exchanged: it differences the pre-post change among Democrats against the pre-post change among Republicans, holding the age group A fixed. Evaluated at $A = a$, it measures how far apart the members of the same cohort moved across the event window.

I implement all DID analyses using a dynamic event study model:

$$y_{iat} = \theta_a + \delta_t + \sum_{\tau=-q, \tau \neq -1}^m \beta_\tau D_{a\tau} + \gamma' X_{iat} + \epsilon_{iat} \quad (4)$$

where a indexes age group (the young and the old), τ indexes the event-time relative to the killing of George Floyd at time t^* , θ_a are age group fixed effects, δ_t are time fixed effects, $D_{a\tau}$ is an indicator equal to one for individuals in the younger age group observed at event-time τ and zero otherwise, β_τ captures the young-old gap at event-time τ relative to $\tau = -1$, and X_{iat} includes controls.

I adjust for one's sex (measured simply as *male* and *female*), level of education, geographic location, measured as congressional district and county, as well as political attention. The exclusion of these adjustments does not alter the findings, and the stability in pre-trends holds with or without these adjustments. I use survey weights and heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors throughout these analyses. While one might theoretically cluster standard errors by birth group to account for

shared group-level shocks, standard cluster-robust estimators are unreliable with small number of groups. More importantly, in what follows, the heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are actually wider and more conservative compared to the estimates I generated by cluster-robust alternatives.

Findings

The trajectory of attitudes toward law enforcement

Figure 3 presents DID estimates from CCES, where people aged 18–29 in 2020 make up the younger cohorts, while those aged 30 and older in 2020 make up the older ones. The killing of George Floyd and the ensuing BLM mobilization resulted in an average differentiation of 11 percent on attitudes toward the police. These differences remained largely constant 2 years later.¹¹ Looking within cohorts, the partisan gap was about 0.09 among the young before the event, which increased to 0.38 after the event. Among the old, these magnitudes were 0.07 and 0.16, respectively. On average, the excess divide among the young relative to the old was 0.19, with a $P < .001$.

Cohortization dynamics in Nationscape

Table S6 presents DID estimates of the changes in unfavorable attitudes toward law enforcement following the killing of George Floyd in Nationscape, comparing individuals aged 29 or younger in 2020 to older cohorts. Once again, the response to the killing of George Floyd and the BLM was stronger among younger individuals compared to the older individuals. Averaging across all partisan groups, the young-old divide in unfavorable attitudes increased by 0.07 on a 0–1 scale, a differentiation of 0.21 standard deviations (SD) of the pre-event distribution. This average, however, masks substantial partisan heterogeneity. Among Democrats and Independents, this differentiation increased by 0.11 (0.34 SD) and 0.06 (0.21 SD), respectively, while among Republicans the gap only increased by 0.01 (0.04 SD), which is not different from zero at $P < .05$. Consistent with Hypothesis 1, the change in attitudes toward law enforcement was concentrated among the young, with this gap varying by partisan identity.

Consistent with Hypothesis 2, changes in attitudes toward US law enforcement persisted among younger Democrats, while fading for older cohorts and younger Republicans. Figure S1 provides a descriptive representation of these opinion dynamics, where I show the trajectory of unfavorable attitudes for each group over time, with each cell normalized to the window immediately preceding the killing of George Floyd. The figure shows that, averaging over the final three windows, young Democrats retained 66 percent of their initial changes against 25 percent among older Democrats, a difference of 42 percentage points (significant at $P < .001$). Among Republicans, neither age group retained any of its initial change, though with initial updates this small the two shares are comparable.¹²

To put these polarization dynamics in context, Figure S2 presents the results from a set of dynamic DID specifications. In doing so, the top panel investigates differences between the young and the old across the full sample while the bottom panel explores these dynamics *within each party*. The results suggest that the polarization in attitudes between the younger and the older individuals toward law enforcement persisted for at least half a year subsequent to the event among Democrats and Independents. Among Republicans, however, these initial updates quickly washed away, the young falling in line with the old individuals in their perceptions of the police.¹³

Looking *within* cohorts, however, we observe an internal ideological differentiation as well. Prior to the event, the baseline partisan gap in attitudes toward the US police between young Democrats and Republicans was about 0.21 points, while it was about 0.11 among the old. After these events, these internal divides increased to 0.37 among the young (a change of 0.16, with $P < .001$) and 0.18 among the old (a change of 0.07, with $P < .001$). That said, the partisan gap widened significantly more among the young than the old following the events, with an excess polarization of 0.09 among the young, relative to the old (with $P < .001$). Such a differential polarization against a pre-event gap of 0.21 means that the excess polarization was roughly 44 percent of the original gap, which suggests that the effect of the event is very large in absolute terms, not just statistically significant.

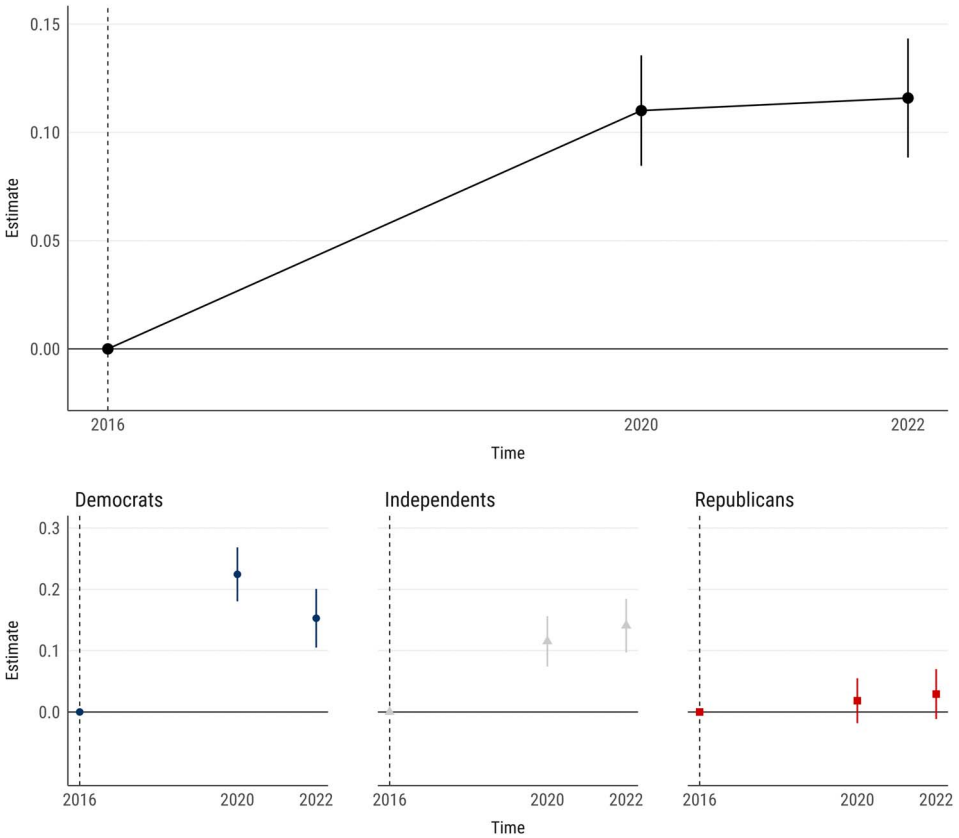


Figure 3 Dynamic difference-in-differences on “feeling unsafe” with the police.

Notes: The figure presents difference-in-differences estimates that measure the diverging trajectories of the young (age 29 or younger in 2020) and the old (age 30 or older in 2020) in the Cooperative Congressional Election Study’s 2016–2022 data file. The model in the top panel adjusts for sex, party identification, education, and political attention, with fixed effects for age at 2020, survey year, and county. The models in the bottom panels perform the same estimations within each party, without the adjustment for party identification, with the 2016 wave as the reference in both panels. Estimates are weighted, and the intervals show 95 percent confidence intervals from heteroskedasticity–robust standard errors.

Analyses that use repeated cross-section surveys help us understand trajectories across groups, but they cannot evaluate changes at the individual level. To address this problem, I used data from the panel components of the 2016, 2020, and 2024 ANES surveys. The police thermometer question in 2020 was asked in the survey’s post-election field, which was conducted between November 8, 2020 and January 4, 2021—roughly five and a half months after the killing of George Floyd. Therefore, it stands as a reasonable test of whether the effects observed in the Nationscape and the CCES may be observed when tracking the same set of individuals across time. Due to ANES’s short window (only three waves) and its sample size ($N = 1,507$), this analysis is highly conservative.

Cohortization dynamics in ANES

Table 1 presents the central findings, revealing a clear pattern: individuals between the ages of 18 and 29 in 2020 changed more strongly than individuals aged 30 and older, and this effect was exclusively concentrated among Democrats rather than Republicans. While estimating these

Table 1 Difference-in-differences models estimating the police thermometer in ANES.

	Democrats	Republicans
Young ×2020	15.00 (4.62)	7.86 (4.47)
Young ×2024	11.06 (4.35)	2.28 (4.57)
Survey Mode: Web	1.39 (2.51)	−2.29 (2.06)
Respondent FEs	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes
N	1572	1767
Unique N	524	589
R ²	0.76	0.65

Notes: Estimates are from difference-in-differences models. The sample is restricted to respondents who identify with the same party across all three waves. The outcome is the police feeling thermometer, recoded so that higher values represent colder feelings, and the 2016 wave is the reference. Both models adjust for survey mode, with respondent and year fixed effects. Estimates are weighted, with standard errors clustered on respondents in parentheses.

models, I restricted the ANES sample to participants who were consistent partisans in the study window ($N = 1,113$). Looking at the coefficients, we see that polarization between younger and older individuals was fifteen points on a 0–100 scale (0.80 SD) in 2020, and roughly eleven points of this change significantly persisted 4 years later. Among Republicans, there was no such significant change.¹⁴ Given that the panel structure resolves potential compositional changes that would violate stable composition assumption, this finding provides a significant confirmation of the main hypotheses.¹⁵ I investigate the behaviors of the remaining individuals below.

Looking within cohorts, we observe similar trajectories. The partisan gap was almost equal among the young and the old before the event, with both groups having a **twelve**-point partisan gap. By 2024, however, this gap increased to 27 among the young (a change of 15, with $P < .05$), while increasing to 18 among the old (a change of 6, with $P < .01$). While the excess partisan gap among the young relative to the old is estimated to be 9, which represents 73 percent of the prior gap, it is not significant (with $p \approx 0.17$), likely due to small sample size inflating the standard errors. These ANES results thus provide support for between- and within-polarization, but not for excess polarization.

Adjudicating alternative processes

The analyses so far establish three findings across three surveys. First, younger individuals moved further than older individuals in their attitudes toward US law enforcement. Second, these initial responses decayed at very different rates, with younger individuals retaining more of their updates than older individuals. Third, these between-cohort differences were additionally accompanied by within-cohort differentiation, a pattern significantly more pronounced among younger individuals. While the model is consistent with each of these patterns, there are several alternative accounts that can explain these findings without invoking differential updating. For instance, it could be that the patterns are due to people changing their party identification rather than changing their attitudes. It could also be that younger and older individuals might have differentially changed their patterns of media consumption after the killing of George Floyd in which case the age differentiation follows differential exposure only. Finally, the young may have been concentrated in local areas where the protest mobilization was the largest, which would account for their differential updating patterns. In this section, I take each of these explanations in turn and evaluate their competing merits.

Compositional partisan change

The findings described so far, with the exception of ANES, cannot distinguish two scenarios. First, individuals' update trajectories may have depended on their initial partisan dispositions. This would support the general model. Second, however, it is also plausible to think that individuals update their initial party identification to reflect their new attitudes. This would imply that compositional changes in party identification can lead to the same results.

To evaluate this possibility, I conducted two analyses. Since Nationscape and CCES are time-series cross-sectional datasets, we cannot observe the same individuals over time. However, both datasets included participants' vote recalls from 2016. We may, in principle, operationalize these responses as the prior partisan orientations of participants. Of course, even assuming that recall bias is negligible, this approach cannot properly disentangle partisan switching from unstable partisanship. It can, however, assess the extent to which the results hinge on alternative specifications. This constitutes the first analysis. The second analysis involves the remaining $N = 394$ individuals in ANES to see how changing partisan trajectories are reflected in changing attitudes toward the police. While the number of young individuals is very low in this group, limiting age-based analyses, it may still give us an understanding of how attitudes toward the police change alongside partisanship.

Figure 4 presents the findings from these analyses. Both the top and the middle panels demonstrate that, by 2016 vote recall, the results are very stable and in the expected direction.¹⁶ Using previous vote choice, particularly among those who voted, means that these age groups are older (that is, the number of individuals categorized as young becomes smaller when I condition on having voted in 2016), leading to relatively imprecise and attenuated estimates in certain cells. Still, these estimates suggest that the results are largely comparable even when we condition on 2016 vote choice.

Looking at the ANES, there are several patterns. With one exception, none of the trajectories shows movement in the police thermometer. Destabilizing Democrats—those who became Independents or Republicans in 2020 and 2024—however, show *increased* favorability of the police in this period, suggesting that those leaving the Democratic party after the event may have contributed to changes in attitudes. While sample size does not allow me to disaggregate this group by their birth cohort, I can quantify their effect on the estimates by including this group first among consistent Democrats, then among consistent Republicans. To do so, I estimated successive TWFE models, showing that the coefficient estimate for Democrats declines from 13 to 11.9 (a change of 9 percent) with their inclusion, while the coefficient estimate for Republicans changes from 5 to 5.1 (a change of 1 percent). These small changes indicate that, overall, compositional changes cannot account for the main conclusions.

Age-segmented media exposure

An alternative explanation might propose that differential media consumption between younger and older individuals might drive these basic findings. Rather than reflecting a process of cohortization, the trajectories we observe thus simply result from differential changes in people's media consumption patterns, independent of any age-based mechanisms.

To evaluate this possibility, I turn to Nationscape and CCES. The former featured several questions about where participants "might have heard news about politics," including responses about social media, local newspapers, CNN, MSNBC, Fox News, Network News, Local TV, Telemundo, NPR, AM Talk Radio, and national newspapers such as The New York Times. The latter featured a more limited set of channels (TV, newspapers, radio, as well as social media), though it included political social media behaviors that provide a profile of consumption (posting a comment on politics, watching or reading stories related to politics, following political events, and forwarding posts or events to other people). For each dataset, I used nearest neighbor matching with three units to match respondents within each unique time period using these media items, alongside gender, education, and partisan identity. To control for differential political attention, I interacted

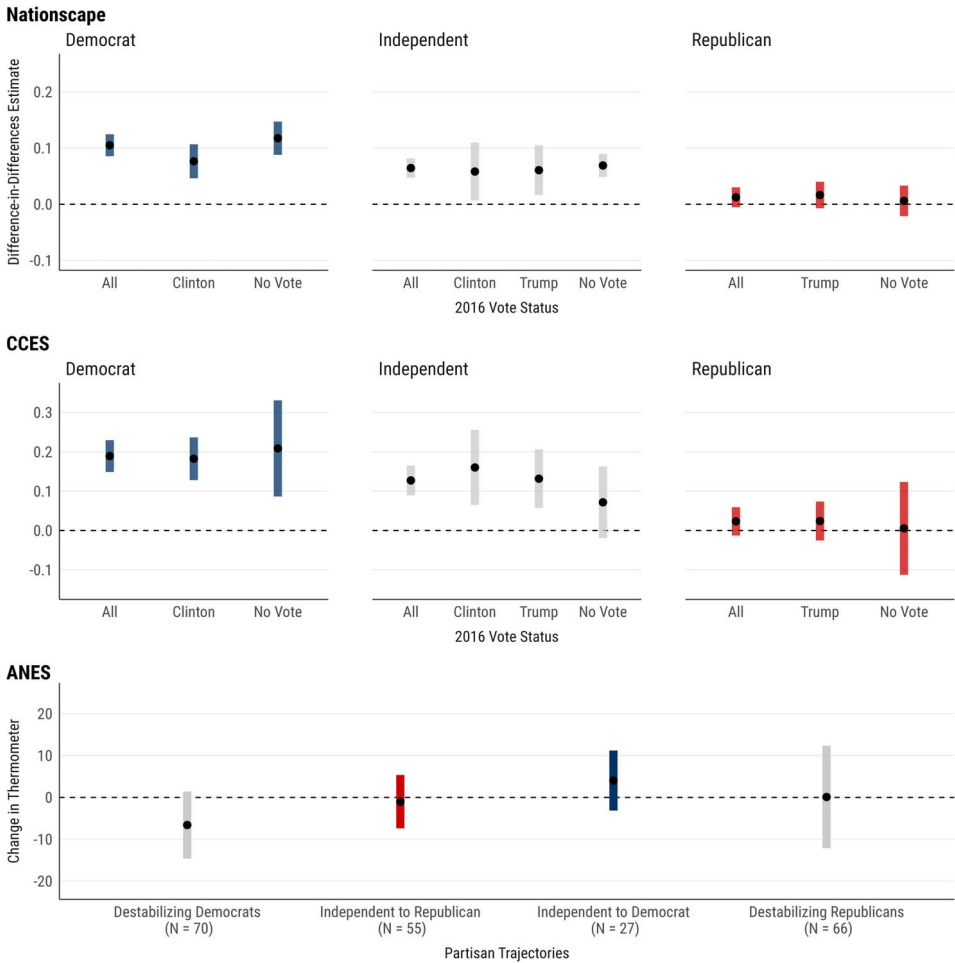


Figure 4 Compositional changes in party identification.

Notes: The top panel presents difference-in-differences estimates of attitudinal differentiation between the young and the old across political parties and 2016 vote recall in the Nationscape. The middle panel presents difference-in-differences estimates of attitudinal differentiation between the young and the old across political parties and 2016 vote recall in the CCES. The bottom panel presents estimates of change from the ANES, defined as the update from pre-event attitudes to the average of post-event attitudes (estimated, once again, via fixed effects models), across four groups: *Destabilizing Democrats*, those who switched from being a democrat to being an Independent or Republican after the event; *Independent to Republican*, those who switched from being an Independent to being a republican after the event; *Independent to Democrat*, those who switched from being an independent to being a Democrat after the event, and *Destabilizing republicans*, those who switched from being a Republican to being an Independent or a Democrat after the event. All estimates are weighted, and the intervals show 95 percent confidence intervals from heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors in the top and middle panels and from standard errors clustered on respondents in the bottom panel.

each media variable with participant political attention levels. In the final step, I estimated within-party models to see whether the findings hold within these matched samples compared to the original samples.¹⁷

Figure 5 presents the results. The left panel shows the standardized mean distances in unmatched and matched samples, suggesting that the matching was largely successful—with

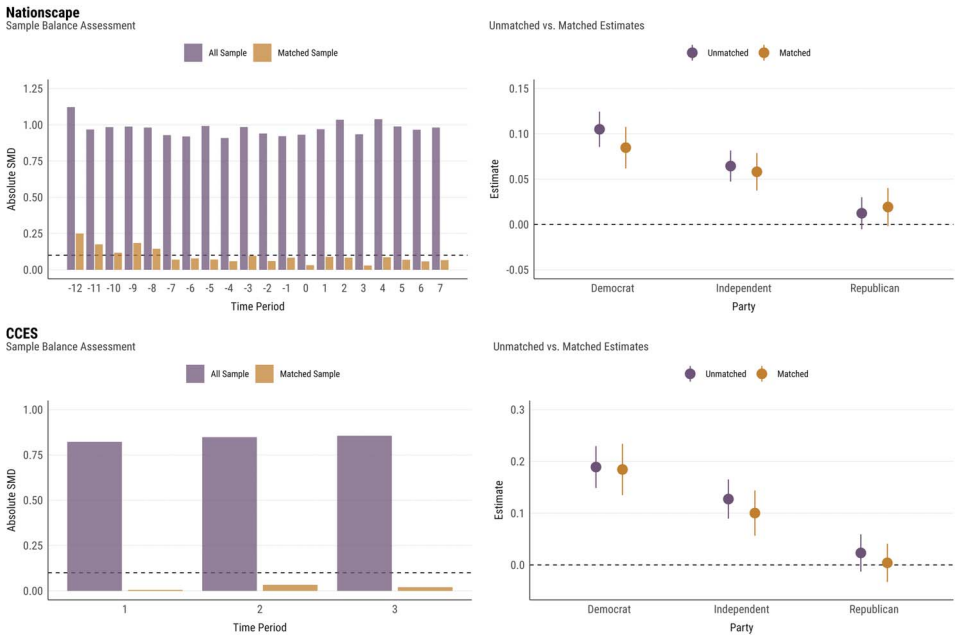


Figure 5 Difference-in-differences analyses on matched samples.

Notes: The top panel presents the analyses for Nationscape, with the left figure showing standardized mean differences across matched and unmatched samples, while the right figure showing estimates from difference-in-differences analyses in the matched sample. Similarly, the bottom panel presents the analyses for the CCES using the same protocol.

few exceptions—in generating comparable samples. The right panel shows the results from DID analyses within groups, confirming that the findings remain largely stable when using the matched samples. While media consumption is surely endogenous in various ways, and it requires a much more in-depth examination, these results provide greater confidence in the central findings.¹⁸

Exposure to BLM mobilization

One final potential explanation is that the process of cohortization disguises differential environmental processes. Considering the age range of younger individuals, it might be the case that those who are in college also reside in predominantly college towns, which had more exposure to BLM. It might also be the case that the intensity of protests in a given region exposes the young to different considerations, which drive them to update their beliefs. Given that the BLM protests primarily occurred in Democratic areas, I might be picking up local effects.

In Figure 6, I show results from TWFE models with treatment-by-protest-intensity interactions, as measured in the Crowd Counting Consortium. The estimates show that proximity to high-protest districts does not lead to differential effects on within and between cohort polarization.¹⁹

Political attention as a mechanism of cohortization

While the life-course *timing* of an exogenous political event is consequential for whether that event will prove effective, it is also correct that cohorts must actually allocate some of their finite attention to the issues related to those events. Considering that attention is scarce and selective, this model implies that only a limited subset of issues will successfully imprint within any given cohort. In a world of many potential political issues, a young generation cannot deeply absorb them all; instead, they will strongly socialize into just those issues that happened to gain significant public attention

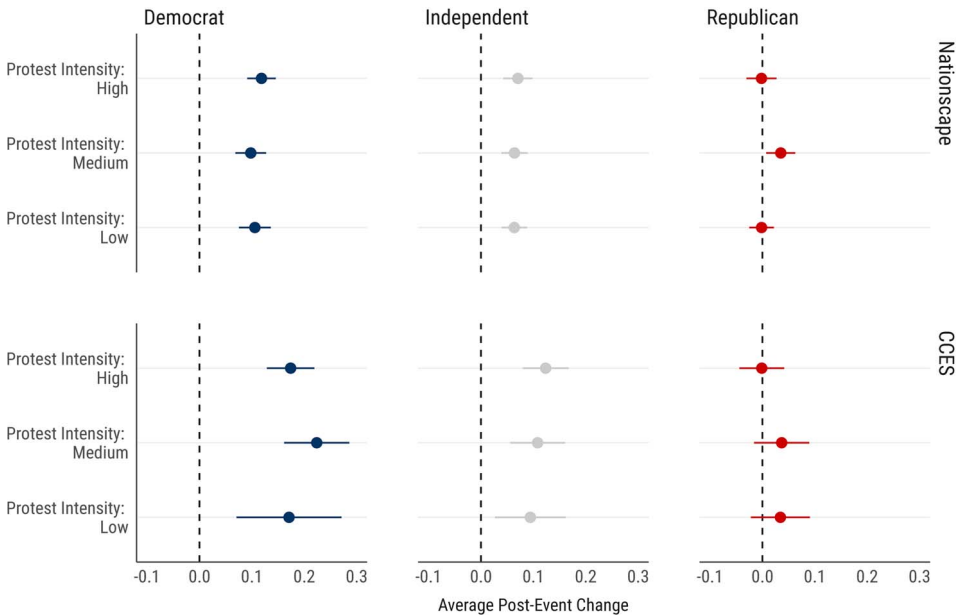


Figure 6 Differential effects via exposure to BLM protests.

Notes: The figure tests whether local exposure to protests moderates the main differentiation effects within party groups, by presenting TWFE estimates with treatment-by-protest-intensity interactions, as measured in the CCC.

during their formative years. This implies that, with a limited *attention budget*, the issues in question should be able to overwhelm others; put differently, their attention share must increase.

I test one implication from this framework: when prompted to think about sociopolitical problems facing the United States, responses should be unevenly distributed across age and partisan groups, such that younger individuals identifying as Democrats and Independents should report problems related to race and policing more often spontaneously. I use the coded open-ended responses from Gallup Poll Social Series and the American National Election Studies for this analysis. In the former case, I treated responses saying “race relations” and “police brutality” in Gallup surveys as one of the three most important problems in the United States. In the latter case, I coded “race relations” and “police issues” if participants mentioned them in their open-ended responses to ANES. While the Gallup survey ranges from January 2020 to November 2021, the ANES includes 2016 and 2020.

Figure 7 presents the results from the Gallup Poll Social Series, while Figure 8 presents the results from the ANES. Three empirical conclusions emerge from these findings. First, there was indeed a sizable attention gap between younger individuals and older individuals in the United States when it comes to perceiving issues related to race and policing as the most important problems. Second, this attention strongly increased from 2016 to 2020, much more so among younger individuals, in response to the killing of George Floyd. Third, while we know that attitudes persist among younger individuals, the attention allocated to race relations and policing steadily declined, suggesting that the imprinting process does not necessarily depend on sustained differential attention.

Discussion and conclusions

Taken together, the evidence presented in this article supports a unified consideration-based model of generational imprinting. This framework provides a micro-foundation for cohort differentiation,

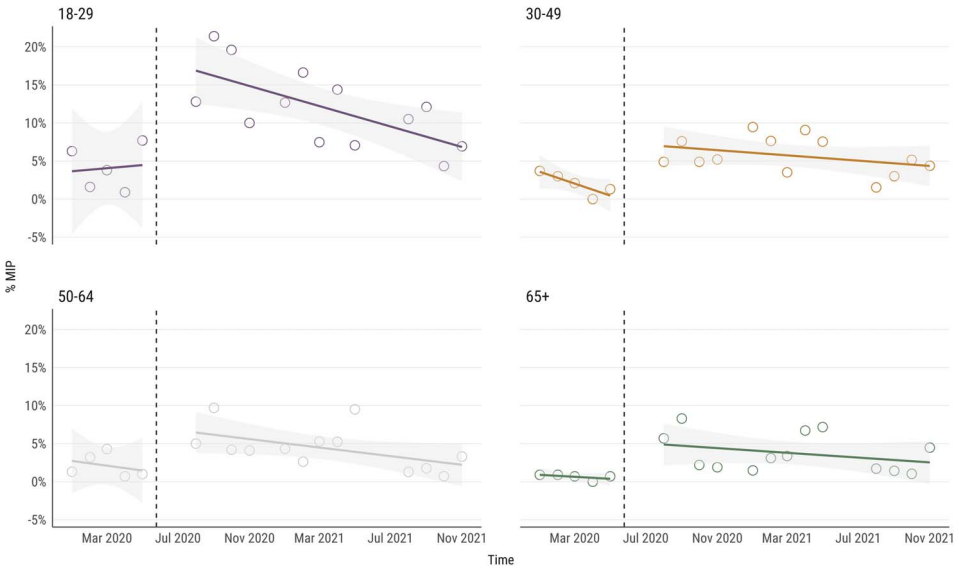


Figure 7 The share of “race relations” and “police brutality” as MIP.

Notes: The figure presents the percentage of respondents, stratified across age groups, who report “race relations” and “police brutality” as one of three “most important problems” in the United States based on the Gallup Poll Social Series.

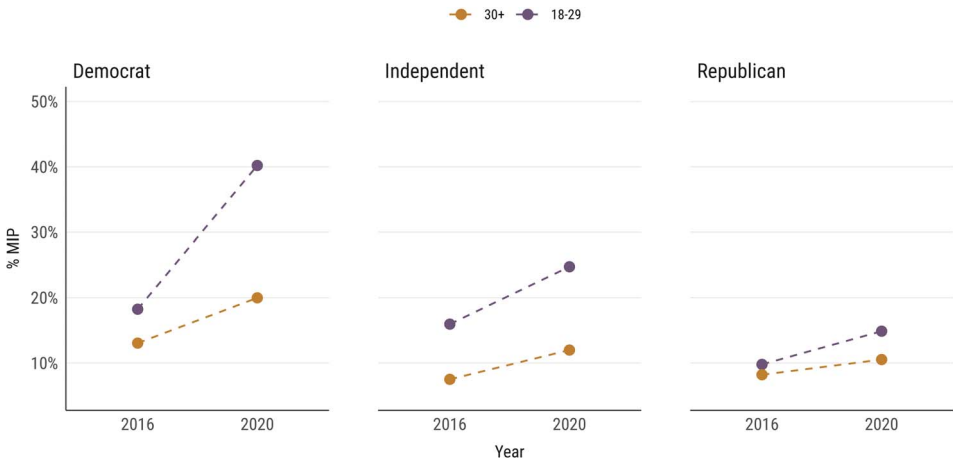


Figure 8 The share of “race relations” and “police problems” as MIP.

Notes: The figure presents the percentage of respondents, stratified across age and party identification, who report “race relations” and “police problems” as one of the “most important problems” in the United States based on the ANES.

arguing that an individual’s response to a political event is a joint function of the dispositions that pattern which considerations they come to hold (Premise 1) as well as the composition of the prior considerations those new interpretations must compete with (Premise 2). The joint effect of these two mechanisms is not really a coherent generational response, but a generation internally divided, a within-cohort differentiation that the between-cohort frameworks typically obscure.

These findings have important consequences for how we think about aggregate political or cultural change. Work on generational replacement typically investigates between-cohort differentiation to understand society-wide changes in personal culture (e.g., [Bartels and Jackman 2014](#); [Grasso et al. 2019](#); [Vaisey and Lizardo 2016](#)), with public preferences changing as a consequence of how entering and exiting cohorts differ from one another. Yet, two cohorts may have an identical central tendency with starkly different internal structures. Interpreting these central tendencies without an analysis of variance in positions would provide misleading conclusions on political or cultural change. The framework advocated in this article instead suggests that the consequences of cohort replacement also depend on how a cohort is internally organized around a common political conflict.

Theoretical and empirical limitations

There are, however, several limitations of this article that should temper the broader implications. First, the killing of George Floyd and the ensuing BLM mobilization constitute an unusually visible and racially charged episode of political mobilization in US history. Whether smaller-scale shocks and non-racialized issues would produce comparable findings remains to be established. While the strongly salient nature of the event provides a useful boundary condition, at the level of individual variation, there might be a variety of alternative processes shaping differential response.

Second, the estimates range between 2016 and 2024. While the post-event window is long enough to show that the divergence outlasted the event, it is far too short to establish generational imprinting. Given that Premise 3 requires that generational differentiation becomes imprinting only if the differences survive over the life course, these analyses cannot establish imprinting. There might be at least two processes that can reverse these results over the life-course. First, it can be that younger respondents come to evaluate the police differently as they age due to a maturation effect. Second, later shocks over the life-course may also change attitudes across cohorts unevenly, overwhelming the differences I observed in this period. Neither possibility can be adjudicated with 8 years of observation, and neither will be settled for good for many decades. Therefore, the analyses in this article suggest an impulse toward cohortization, leaving the question of imprinting open.

Third, age effects in cross-sectional surveys conflate age, period, and cohort pathways ([Fosse and Winship 2019](#)), and the causal status of age remains ambiguous in the literature (but see [Kratz and Brüderl 2025](#)). I conceptualize cohort effects as age-by-period interactions, but the single-event design used here cannot cleanly identify the sources of variation ([Dinas and Stoker 2014](#)). A stronger separation of these processes thus requires either repeated events or longer panel data, neither of which is available for the case at hand. Given that the killing of George Floyd and the ensuing BLM mobilization was a population-wide event, however, I have important design limitations.

Implications

These findings support the view that shared experiences do not necessarily lead to convergent political attitudes, as these experiences are filtered through the political information environment. Instead, cohorts become differentiated into what [Mannheim \(1952\)](#) calls *generation-units*: subgroups within cohorts oriented toward the same political object through different interpretive standpoints. In contemporary US politics, political parties provide the interpretive “scaffolding” for these units. The sorting process thus channels shared experiences, producing cohort differentiation rather than uniform convergence. Hence, one implication of this paper is to theorize generational polarization not as cohort replacement alone but as cohort-structured sorting within party coalitions.

Ultimately, this article provides a useful corrective to classic narratives about generations. Instead of treating cohorts as passive recipients of “shared experiences,” this article theorizes the

political field as a structuring force that actively channels those experiences. Using this insight to develop a micro-level mechanism of generational differentiation, I argue that a more processual understanding of generational imprinting can provide a better explanation for generational politics.

Addendum on reproducibility

Reproduction materials

The data and code that reproduce the full set of analyses are provided at <https://osf.io/dq8j5>.

Artificial intelligence usage statement

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About the authors

Turgut Kesintürk is a Ph.D. Candidate in Sociology at Duke University. The main goal of his research is to understand how cultural and political preferences form early in life and persist into adulthood. His work appeared in *Sociological Science*, *Poetics*, and *Political Psychology*.

Endnotes

1. I would like to thank an anonymous reviewer for suggesting this apt characterization of opinion dynamics.
2. See [Bartels and Jackman \(2014\)](#) for a succinct formal treatment that brings Bayesian and generational learning together. In their theory, cohort differentiation endogenously emerges from the interaction of age and period-specific shocks, and the main assumption generating this prediction is the notion that people of different ages possibly attach different weights to exogenous political shocks or proposals from the environment. The differences in the composition of these proposals lead to a differentiation in the experiences of cohorts, which then produces cohort differentiation. Similarly, see [Ghitza, Gelman and Auerbach \(2023\)](#) for a comparable treatment. The problem is that this work quantifies cohort differences via backward tracing from aggregate data without really unpacking the process of cohortization itself.
3. As [Ryder \(1965, 850\)](#) puts, “the entry of fresh cohorts into the political stream represents a potentiality for change, but without specification of its *content* or *direction*” (emphases added). Similar problems are raised in [Mannheim \(1952\)](#).
4. While an actor, according to this account, disproportionately comes to hold considerations congruent with what they already are, this differential acceptance might be due to directional motives ([Kahan 2017](#); [Williams 2023](#)), or because individuals are perfect Bayesians though with different exposure histories ([Achen 1992](#); [Bartels and Jackman 2014](#)). These two micro-mechanisms are observationally equivalent in most, if not all, empirical contexts (e.g., [Little 2025](#)).
5. Importantly, within-cohort differentiation is the theory’s discriminating prediction: the observable outcome that separates this account from frameworks built on theories of formative experiences alone.
6. There is now a sizable scholarly literature on the influence of the killing of George Floyd and the BLM. Existing studies have typically asked whether protest exposure and proximity produced attitude changes among the US public (e.g., [Engelhardt and Kam 2025](#); [Gethin and Pons 2024](#); [Reny and Newman 2021](#)). This research often reported that these attitude changes were rather small ([Gethin and Pons 2024](#)) or not durable ([Reny and Newman 2021](#)). None,

however, considered the idea that the event may have catalyzed a cohortization process among young Americans.

7. See Anoll and Engelhardt (2023) for a similar argument on how unique histories with US institutions may “produce divergent foundations for integrating new information in the form of direct experiences into political views” (1,150).
8. The non-Hispanic Whites also have a higher internal political heterogeneity, compared to substantial levels of partisan sorting among ethnoracial minorities, making the former more appropriate for an analysis of partisan differentiation. According to the two-party share estimates of Cooperative Congressional Election Study, for instance, almost 90 percent of Black Americans in 2020 voted for the Democratic Party. This share is less than 43 percent for White Americans.
9. See Supplemental Materials A for the complete survey questions.
10. That said, Table S10 in the Supplemental Materials suggests that the responses to this survey item in 2016 (before the event) sharply diverged by partisan identification, implying that the underlying construct was already politicized.
11. Table S8 in the Supplemental Materials shows these models under alternative specifications, where I drop the survey weights, restrict the partisan panels to those recalling a vote for their party’s candidate in 2016, assign age groups by age at interview, or keep only the birth cohorts present in all three waves. All estimates are substantively similar.
12. Table S11 in the Supplemental Materials aggregates the young–old differences across all pre-event windows. None of the four estimates differs from zero, indicating that the two age groups were on comparable trajectories.
13. Table S7 in the Supplemental Materials shows these models under alternative specifications, where I drop the survey weights, remove the “haven’t heard enough” responses, use a binary outcome, or use ideological identity in place of partisan identity. All estimates are substantively similar.
14. Due to low sample sizes, I could not incorporate consistent Independents as a separate group.
15. Table S9 in the Supplemental Materials shows these models under alternative specifications, where I drop the survey weights, define the panels by partisanship in 2016 instead of the full trajectory, drop the control for survey mode, or cluster the standard errors on the sampling unit. All estimates are substantively similar.
16. I purposefully excluded “partisan switchers” (Democrats who were Trump voters in 2016 and Republicans who were Clinton voters in 2016) as their numbers were very small, resulting in large and highly imprecise estimates.
17. I matched 3 “control” units to each “treatment” unit, though using less or more leads to the same findings. I also used the same specifications I used in the matching process while estimating the regression models.
18. Of course, because the DID framework inherently absorbs static baseline differences in media consumption between the young and the old respondents, the primary alternative explanation is that the observed attitude changes were driven entirely by differential changes in respondents’ media behavior. By matching respondents on contemporaneous media profiles within each time period, this analysis deliberately adjusts for these post-event pathways.
19. I present three further tests in the Supplemental Materials. Figure S3 replaces the binary age variable used in the ANES analyses with a spline, showing that the change scores decrease smoothly with age among Democrats while staying near zero among Republicans. Figure S4 uses the ANES Social Media Study, where both waves were fielded after the killing of George Floyd, and finds that younger respondents changed more in absolute terms, while the direction of change was indistinguishable across age groups. This suggests that, while a general tendency of the young to change more can produce differences in magnitude, it cannot produce the directional changes documented here. Figure S5 estimates the same models for fourteen items in the Nationscape, none of which shows a young–old differentiation at the time of the

event, indicating that the divergence documented above is specific to attitudes toward law enforcement.

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Supplementary material

Supplementary material is available at *Social Forces* online.

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Conflicts of interest

None declared.

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